The Family Medicaid Planning Checklist

What to organize now, what to ask a professional about and what to keep an eye on.

Mom is managing on her own, and nothing needs deciding today. That leaves room for a list. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is simply something for another day, not a sign that anything is wrong.

Organize now

- [ ] A short, dated note on how Mom is managing today: what she does on her own, and where someone already lends a hand.
- [ ] What she has said she'd want if she needed more help one day, in her own words.
- [ ] A one-page summary of her finances in round numbers: what comes in, what she has, what she owes.
- [ ] What you've read or been told about Medicaid so far, with who said it. Where two people said different things, write down both.
- [ ] A list of the legal documents you know she has, such as her will, with where each is kept and the date on it.
- [ ] The family members who should take part in planning, with a phone number for each, and a word to each about where these papers are kept. [1]

Ask a professional about

- [ ] The things your family has thought about doing. Write the list, and mark anything that involves moving, gifting or retitling money or property, creating or changing a legal document, or buying or cancelling insurance as “ask first.”
- [ ] Which kind of professional each open question belongs to: your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial or insurance professional, or a tax professional.
- [ ] Who Mom would want handling her money matters and her healthcare decisions if she couldn't. Write down what she says, and take the question of what that requires to an elder law attorney.
- [ ] The insurance she already has, listed by company and kind of policy, with one question for a licensed insurance professional: what does each one cover?
- [ ] Whether anything in what you've gathered needs a closer look. That is a question for your Medicaid planner, not something to work out at the kitchen table.

Keep an eye on

- [ ] The things your family has agreed simply to watch, written as a short list.
- [ ] The changes your family says would make you pick this up again. Some to talk over: a hospital stay, a new diagnosis, changes in memory, needing more help with daily activities, a family caregiver needing more support, a move to a care facility, or care costs rising. The list is yours to write.

- [ ] When you'll next look at this page together. Pick a date that suits your family and write it at the top.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you organize, ask and keep watch. It doesn't say what any item means for Mom, what should be done now or what can wait, or whether anything on it is a concern. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional, and to the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've sorted what to organize, what to ask about and what to keep an eye on. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 follows AARP's legal checklist for family caregivers, which suggests making sure family members know where the documents are. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers